

Modern Apostles

prc-modern-apostles

Spiritual Gifts · Offices · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.975
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The office of apostle in the foundational, Scripture-authoring sense (eyewitness of the risen Christ, sent with Christ's authority to lay the Church's foundation) was filled by the apostles of Christ and is not continuing today; claims to apostolic *office* in this sense after the apostolic age do not bind the Church's conscience, though missionary church-planting work that is sometimes called "apostolic" in a non-office sense is unaffected.

In plain language

The proposition limits itself to a narrow sense of apostle, the foundational, Scripture-bearing office held by the original group, and it explicitly grants that missionary work sometimes called apostolic is unaffected. On that narrow sense the words in Scripture line up. In Acts 1, when Judas is replaced, Peter sets two entrance requirements: the man must have accompanied the company during all the time the Lord Jesus went in and out among them, beginning from the baptism of John, and he must become a witness of the resurrection. Those are first-generation criteria, datable and not repeatable. Paul defends his own standing in First Corinthians 9 with the question, have I not seen Jesus our Lord, using a perfect-tense verb meaning a past sighting whose result still stands. In First Corinthians 15 Paul lists the resurrection appearances and says, last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me. The phrase last of all closes the appearance series and ranks Paul as the final eyewitness in this category. Ephesians 2 then calls the apostles and prophets the foundation, with Christ as the cornerstone, using building language in which a foundation is laid once and built upon, not added course by course. Revelation 21 fixes the picture: the city has twelve foundations bearing the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb. Jude says the faith was once for all delivered to the saints, using a word that means once for all. Confidence is medium rather than high because the very same Greek word, apostolos, is used in a wider everyday sense of a sent envoy or delegate, as with Epaphroditus in Philippians 2 and the apostles of the churches in Second Corinthians 8. Ephesians 4 also lists apostles in a gift list without specifying whether the gift continues. So the lexical root-cause of the divergence is straightforward: apostolos carries two attested senses, one bounded by the eyewitness criteria of Acts 1 and First Corinthians 15, and one a broader sent-one usage. Readers who restrict the question to the bounded sense agree the office closed; readers who collapse the two senses, or who lean on Ephesians 4 without the Ephesians 2 foundation framing, will read continuation. The proposition picks the bounded sense and the lexical pattern supports it.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3808	לא	lo	not	
H5030	נביא	nabi	prophet	305
G0204	ἀκρογωνιαίος	akrogoniaios	cornerstone	2
G0386	ἀνάστασις	anastasis	resurrection	42

G0530	ἅπαξ	hapax	once	14
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	80
G0721	ἀρνίον	arnion	lamb	31
G1163	δεῖ	dei	be necessary	106
G1427	δώδεκα	dodeka	twelve	81
G1525	εἰσέρχομαι	eiserchomai	to enter	
G1626	ἐκτρωμα	ektroma	untimely birth	1
G1831	ἐξέρχομαι	exerchomai	to go out	
G2026	ἐποικοδομέω	epoikodomeo	to build up/upon	7
G2078	ἔσχατος	eschatos	last/least	52
G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	16
G3144	μάρτυς	martys	witness	35
G3708	ὁράω	horao	to see	61
G3860	παραδίδομι	paradidomi	to deliver	121

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition restricts itself to the foundational, Scripture-authoring apostolic office and explicitly carves out broader sent-one usage. On that narrow sense the lexical pattern lines up. Acts 1.21-22 sets two entrance criteria, companionship of Jesus through the whole earthly ministry, and being a martys, witness, of the anastasis, resurrection. 1Cor 9.1 grounds Paul's claim in heoraka, the perfect of horao, a past sighting whose result still stands. 1Cor 15.8 then places Paul as eschaton de panton, last of all, like an ektroma, an untimely birth, presenting the resurrection-appearance line as a closed series. Eph 2.20 calls the apostles and prophets the themelios, foundation, with Christ as akrogoniaios, cornerstone, and Rev 21.14 fixes the city wall at twelve themelious bearing the twelve apostles' names. Jude 1.3 names the faith as hapax paradotheise, once for all delivered. Confidence is medium not high because apostolos itself is polysemous in the canon (Phil 2.25 Epaphroditus, 2Cor 8.23 apostoloi ekklesion, Rom 16.7) and Eph 4.11 lists apostolous in a gift list without lexically marking duration, so the words alone do not foreclose a non-foundational continuing usage; the verdict holds because the proposition explicitly limits itself to the foundational sense.

Scripture

Acts.1.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1163 δεῖ, G1525 εἰσέρχομαι, G1831 ἐξέρχομαι

Force. Peter sets the necessity, dei, that the replacement be from among the men who were with the company en panti chrono ho eiselthen kai exelthen eph hemas ho kyrios Iesous, in all the time the Lord Jesus went in and out among us, beginning from the baptism of John. The eiselthen and exelthen aorist pair is a finite, datable window of personal accompaniment that cannot be re-entered after the apostolic generation.

Acts.1.22 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3144 μάρτυς, G0386 ανάστασις

Force. The candidate must become *martura tes anastaseos autou syn hemin*, a witness with us of his resurrection. The defining content of the office is firsthand testimony to the risen Christ. The criterion is personal sensory eyewitness, which forecloses any candidate who did not see the risen Lord.

1Cor.9.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 απόστολος, G3708 ὥραω

Force. Paul stakes his apostleship on *ouchi lesoun ton kurion hemon heoraka*, have I not seen Jesus our Lord. *Heoraka* is the perfect active of *horao*, a past act of seeing whose effect abides. Paul uses the same grammatical move that Acts 1.22 demands of any candidate, attesting that the lexical entrance criterion is consistent across the eyewitness apostolate.

1Cor.15.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: simile

Key terms. G2078 ἔσχατος, G1626 ἔκτρωμα

Force. Paul lists the resurrection appearances and at the end says *eschaton de panton hosperei to ektromati ophthe kamoi*, last of all, as to one untimely born, he appeared also to me. *Eschaton panton*, last of all, presents the post-resurrection appearance series as a closed enumeration. *Ektroma* is a hapax in the New Testament that marks Paul's appearance as out-of-sequence and final. The vocabulary itself ranks Paul as the last witness in this category, which is the strongest lexical case that the eyewitness apostolate is a bounded series and not a continuing one.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G0204 ἀκρογωνιαίος, G2026 ἐποικοδομέω

Force. Believers are *epoikodomethentes epi to themelio ton apostolon kai propheton*, built up on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus being *akrogoniaiou*, the cornerstone. *Epoikodomethentes* is an aorist passive participle, a completed action of being built up. *Themelios* in construction language is what is laid first and once and then built upon. *Akrogoniaios* is itself near-hapax (only Eph 2.20 and 1Pet 2.6, both christological). The architecture argues for a non-repeating base layer.

Rev.21.14 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος, G1427 δώδεκα, G0721 ἄρνιον

Force. The wall of the city has *themelious dodeka kai ep auton dodeka onomata ton dodeka apostolon tou arniou*, twelve foundations and on them the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb. The number *dodeka* is fixed and recurs three times in the verse for the foundations, names, and apostles, presenting the foundational apostolate as a closed and enumerated set rather than an open continuing office.

Jude.1.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0530 ἅπαξ, G3860 παραδίδωμι

Force. The faith is described as *tei hapax paradotheisei tois hagiois pistei*, the faith once for all delivered to the saints. Hapax in this usage means once for all, decisively and not to be repeated (cf. Heb 9.26-28 of Christ's offering, 1Pet 3.18 of his death). *Paradotheise* is an aorist passive participle of *paradidomi*, a completed act of handover. A deposit handed over hapax cannot be re-delivered, which closes the foundational, deposit-bearing office that delivered it.

Deut.18.22 · **for** · genre: law

Key terms. H5030 נביא, H3808 לא

Force. The test of a true prophet, nabi, is whether the word comes to pass; if not, lo dibbero YHWH, the LORD has not spoken it. Scripture sets an objective verification criterion for claimed bearers of divine authority. By analogy of Scripture this weighs against unverified claims to a foundational, Scripture-bearing office.

Rom.16.7 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 απόστολος

Force. Andronicus and Junia are episemoi en tois apostolois, notable among the apostles. The phrase is grammatically ambiguous between of note among the apostles (inclusive sense) and well known to the apostles (exclusive sense). Either way the word apostolos here is either the broad sent-one sense or denotes recognition by the apostles, not predication of the foundational eyewitness office of Acts 1.21-22.

Phil.2.25 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0652 απόστολος

Force. Paul calls Epaphroditus humon de apostolon kai leitourgon tes chreias mou, your apostolos and minister of my need. Here apostolos plainly carries the broad sent-one or delegate sense, a commissioned envoy from a local assembly, not a foundational Scripture-authoring office. This is a clear datapoint that apostolos is polysemous in the canon.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.2.20	Eph.4.11	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	Isa.28.16	tsk	1
Eph.2.20	1Pet.2.6	tsk	1
Rev.21.14	Rev.21.19	tsk	1
1Cor.9.1	1Cor.15.8	tsk	1
Acts.1.22	Acts.1.8	tsk	1
Acts.1.22	Acts.10.41	tsk	1
Jude.1.3	Heb.9.26	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Deut.18.20	tsk	1
Deut.18.22	Deut.13.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Eph.4.11 · **addressed**

Christ kai edoken tous men apostolous, gave some as apostles, alongside prophets, evangelists, shepherds and teachers, for the equipping of the saints. The verb didomi, gave, is aorist and does not lexically encode duration. The list names a gift but does not specify whether the office continues or is bounded. The same letter at Eph 2.20 already calls the apostles and prophets the foundation, which is the lexical resource that anchors the boundedness for the Scripture-authoring sense. The words alone leave room for a continuing non-foundational reading of apostolos here, which is the main reason confidence on the broader question is medium rather than high.

2Cor.8.23 · addressed

Paul calls envoys apostoloi ekklesion, apostles of the churches. The genitive ekklesion shows that apostolos here is a representative or delegate of local congregations, not a Scripture-authoring eyewitness office. This is direct lexical evidence that apostolos carries a non-technical congregational sense in the same author who applies the technical sense to himself, demonstrating polysemy.

Rom.16.7 · addressed

Andronicus and Junia are episemoi en tois apostolois. Either reading (notable among them, or well known to them) keeps the term away from the foundational eyewitness criteria; neither reading predicates Acts 1.21-22 companionship plus resurrection eyewitness of these individuals.

Phil.2.25 · addressed

Epaphroditus is humon apostolos, your sent one, the broad delegate sense. The stem itself explicitly carves out this non-office missionary use as unaffected, so this datapoint does not falsify the proposition.

2Cor.12.12 · addressed

Paul speaks of ta semeia tou apostolou, the signs of the apostle, worked among the Corinthians in patience with signs, wonders and powers. The genitive tou apostolou treats apostolos as a recognizable category with attesting signs. This text does not foreclose the foundational reading; rather, it gives the office authenticating marks. Whether such signs accompany only the foundational generation or could recur is not settled by this verse's words alone.

1Cor.15.7 · addressed

Then he appeared to James, eita tois apostolois pasin, then to all the apostles. The use of the article tois apostolois pasin presents a definite, enumerable group already in view by 50s AD, after which 15.8 places Paul as eschaton, last. The pasin (all) closes the set.

Concordance traversed

G0652, G3708, G2310, G0204, G2026, G0386, G3144, G1163, G0530, G3860, G1427, G0721, G2078, G1626, H5030, H3808

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true with an empty variant_units list. The cited verses (Acts 1.21-22, 1Cor 9.1, 1Cor 15.8, Eph 2.20, Jude 1.3, Rev 21.14, Deut 18.21-22) carry no verdict-bearing variant in the supplied apparatus, and the load-bearing terms (apostolos, themelios, hapax, dodeka, dei, anastasis, heoraka, ektroma) are textually stable across the tradition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. cessationism, continuationism, restorationism, broad-sent-one-only

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

cessationism: affirms · Reads Acts 1.21-22 eyewitness criterion, 1Cor 9.1 heoraka, 1Cor 15.8 eschaton panton and ektroma, Eph 2.20 foundation language, Rev 21.14 closed twelve, and Jude 1.3 hapax paradotheise as jointly closing the foundational office with the apostolic generation. The construction-grammar of the foundation metaphor and the bounded series of resurrection appearances are the strongest lexical features.

continuationism: affirms with qualification · Often grants that the foundational eyewitness Scripture-authoring office closed (Acts 1.21-22 cannot be re-entered, 1Cor 15.8 eschaton is decisive) while holding that gift-list apostolos in Eph 4.11 and the sent-one usage in 2Cor 8.23 and Phil 2.25 are real continuing functions. On the strict scope of the proposition this lens is compatible with affirms because the proposition limits itself to the foundational sense

and explicitly carves out missionary apostolic work.

restorationism: denies · Claims a restored governing apostolic office today, often grounding the case on Eph 4.11 (apostles in the gift list with no stated duration), 2Cor 12.12 (signs of an apostle as a recurring category marker), and a non-bounded reading of the broader apostolos uses. In its strongest lexical form, this lens argues that Acts 1.21-22 sets criteria only for the replacement of Judas in the original Twelve and does not legislate apostle-criteria for all generations, and that 1Cor 15.8 eschaton refers to the resurrection-appearance series specifically and not to apostolic office per se. The lens has to reckon with the foundation-metaphor of Eph 2.20 and Rev 21.14 twelve, but reads them as historical descriptors of the founding group rather than a fixed cap.

broad-sent-one-only: denies (in a different sense) · A reading that takes apostolos in its etymological breadth (one sent, from apostello) and resists ranking any New Testament use as a special office. On this lens, Paul, the Twelve, Epaphroditus, and the apostoloi ekklesion of 2Cor 8.23 all participate in the same fundamental category, distinguished only by mission scope. Such a reading would deny that the office in the foundational sense ever existed as a separate category, but it must account for the explicit Acts 1.21-22 criteria and 1Cor 15.8 eschaton, which mark out a distinguishable bounded set.

Verdict turns on the grammatical force of the perfect heoraka and ophthe, the aorist passive participles epoikodomethentes and paradotheise, the closed-series adverb eschaton with the hapax ektroma, the once-for-all force of hapax, and the architectural metaphor of themelios and akrogoniaios. The polysemy of apostolos is the main reason confidence is medium rather than high.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does Scripture's vocabulary present the office of apostle (as the term is used of the Twelve and Paul) as a foundational, bounded category that closed with the apostolic generation, or as a continuing office that can be filled today, and how does it relate to the broader sent-one (apostolos) usage in the New Testament?

The stem builds in a distinction between a foundational, Scripture-authoring eyewitness office and non-office missionary work, and pre-classifies the latter as unaffected. That framing leans toward affirms by isolating the strongest closed case (foundational eyewitness) and exempting the easier polysemy case (sent-one). The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutralized form poses the question without pre-resolving the foundational versus continuing split, and lets the lexical data speak both to the bounded Acts 1.21-22 plus 1Cor 15.8 series and to the polysemy in Phil 2.25 plus 2Cor 8.23.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.9.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.15.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.22
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0652
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0530
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2310
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1626
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3708
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.18.22
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5030
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.2.20
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rev.21.14

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.9.1
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License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

(none)